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n a frozen pond, 3,500 metres above sea level, children skate with wooden sticks in sub-zero temperatures.

Some clear the snow, while others test the ice with sharp skates, gliding past friends and moving the puck like a cherished companion, glued to their hockey sticks.

Winter has arrived in Ladakh – with temperatures remaining well below -5°C throughout the day and often plunging below -20°C at night. The Karzoo pond, which has weeds growing in it in the summer, transforms

into a vibrant field for the fastest team sport in the world.

“This pond is synonymous with Ladakh’s culture. Now, it has become even more significant because children receive coaching here in winter, with the Ladakh Winter Sports Club ensuring the sport progresses,” says Namgyal Tundup, the first captain of India’s ice hockey team, who grew up playing on this very pond.

However, this area, framed by the stunning snow-capped peaks and glaciers of the Himalayas, is among several cold zones enduring the brunt of climate change.

Karzoo is one of many ponds that have served as potential training grounds for ice hockey in Ladakh. Yet, the decline in their number, coupled with rapidly disappearing glaciers, has turned this arid desert into a battleground for the harshest consequences of global warming.

“There has been a definite impact. When we were children, ice would form everywhere. Now, even at Karzoo, I’ll tell you, just a few years ago, the ice did not form as expected,” Namgyal laments.

“Last year was warmer than usual, and in Kargil, there wasn’t enough snow.”

A recent study by Kashmir University’s Geo-Informatics